

Wikidata Queries for Greek and Latin Philology

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Summary

- 1) Introduction to [Wikidata](#) and the [Wikidata Query Service](#);
- 2) Query examples for Wikidata items of the [Pauly's Realencyclopädie der classischen Altertumswissenschaft \(Pauly-Wissowa\)](#);
- 3) Query examples and visualization of Wikidata statements in the [Catalog](#) of the [Linked Ancient Greek and Latin \(LAGL\)](#) project.

1) Introduction to Wikidata and the Wikidata Query Service

Wikidata: a knowledge graph



https://commons.wikimedia.org/w/index.php?lang=en&title=File%3AWikidata_nodes_in_white.svg

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Wikidata: a Wikimedia project



https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wikimedia_logo_family_complete-2023.svg

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Wikidata: a collaborative project

Every month

- 24+ thousands of users edit make at least 1 edit
- 13+ thousands of users edit make at least 5 edits

Every day

- 384+ thousands of edits on items

In total

- 120+ million items and 13+ thousands properties

(statistics as of 15 May 2026, <https://wikidata.wikiscan.org/>)

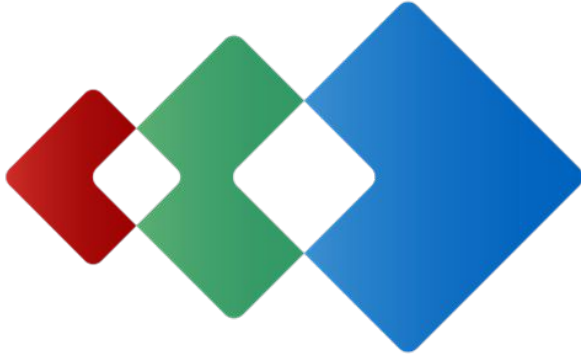
Wikidata: a source of reusable data

All the structured data in Wikidata are released in CC0 (public domain); consequently, they can be reused with no restrictions.

The reuse of Wikidata is vast and not easy to trace for this reason (cf. Google, virtual assistants, AI chatbots etc.). In most cases the data from Wikidata are consumed indirectly and the readers do not know from where they come.

So, it is important to **always cite the source of the data**, for traceability and also to enable the readers to go to the source (Wikidata) and edit the data there, improving them if they want.

Wikidata: a Wikibase instance



https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wikibase_Logo_%E2%80%93_symbol.svg

M.O.R. Design for Wikimedia Deutschland, CC0,
Wikimedia Commons



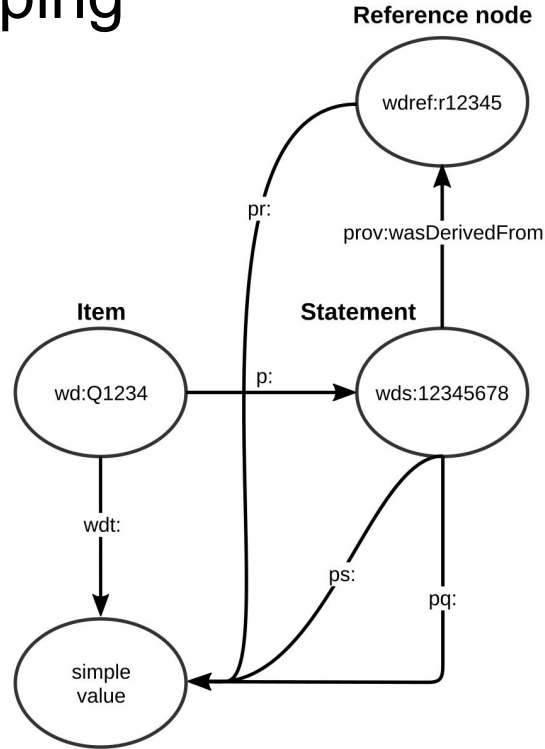
MediaWiki

<https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:MediaWiki-2020-logo.svg>

Serhio Magpie, CC BY-SA 4.0
<<https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>>, Wikimedia Commons

Wikidata RDF mapping

An example item:
<https://www.wikidata.org/wiki/Q135012823>



[https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wikidata_RDF_mapping_\(partial\).svg](https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Wikidata_RDF_mapping_(partial).svg)

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Wikidata: the SPARQL endpoints

- Wikidata Query Service (WDQS): <https://query.wikidata.org/>

The official SPARQL endpoint, with a few useful personalizations absent in standard SPARQL 1.1; its triplestore, Blazegraph, has been unmaintained since 2018 and has many issues - [it will be replaced in 2027 with QLever](#)

- QLever SPARQL Engine - Wikidata: <https://qlever.dev/wikidata/>

Endpoint maintained by the University of Freiburg, which also developed the triplestore QLever; much better performances, it presently lacks the personalizations and some visualization tools present in WDQS; try here if a query times out in WDQS, it will probably work

2) Query examples for Wikidata items of the
*Paulys Realencyclopädie der classischen
Altertumswissenschaft* (Pauly-Wissowa)

Paulys Realencyclopädie der classischen Altertumswissenschaft (RE)

- monumental encyclopedia regarding the classical antiquity, the most comprehensive ever produced
- published in German from 1893 to 1980 (84 volumes, 100+ thousands articles, 1000+ authors)
- still a fundamental reference for a lot of topics, especially for the systematic listing of all the references to ancient passages regarding each topic



https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Pauly-Wissowa_3_retouched.jpg

Jonathan Groß, CC BY 3.0

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RE in German Wikisource

- The transcription started in 2007; this is the present advancement status; [the project of course is ongoing](#)
- The transcribed articles can fix the typos of the original printed text and can be enriched with links, becoming hypertexts
- A lot of articles are still under copyright since their authors are alive, or died less than 70 years ago, so cannot be transcribed (unless they are under the “threshold of originality”)



RE in Wikidata

- Each RE article has an item in Wikidata, once it has been created in Wikisource; note that an article and all its supplements are managed in the same Wikisource page and Wikidata item
- The Wikidata item of the RE article should be connected to the Wikidata item of the entity described in the RE article through “main topic” (P921), and it is linked back through the qualifier “statement is subject of” (P805) of “described by source” (P1343) [[example](#)]

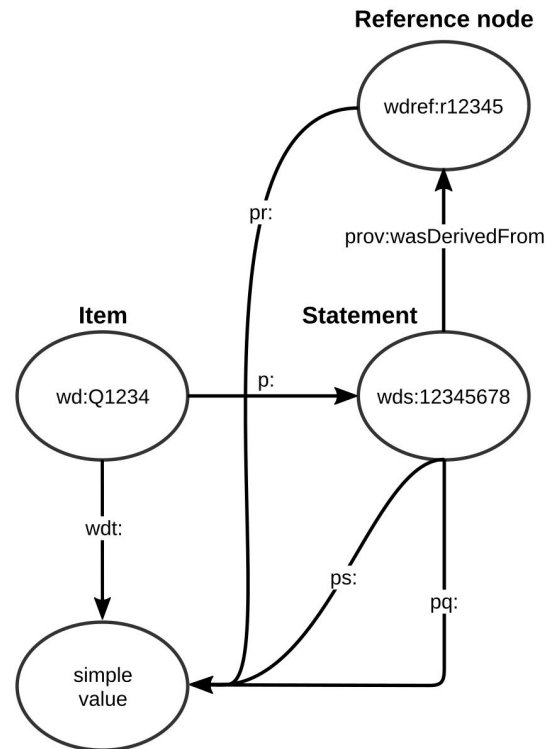
The image shows a complex, multi-colored grid of text, which appears to be a large Wikidata table or a complex data visualization. The text is arranged in many rows and columns, with different colors (green, yellow, red, blue) highlighting various sections or categories. The overall structure is dense and intricate, representing a large dataset or a complex network of information.

Let's query around RE in Wikidata! **[remember, the data are partial]**

Some examples:

- Entities described by RE (<https://w.wiki/NPSi>)
- Persons described by RE (<https://w.wiki/NPSs>)
- Writers described by RE (<https://w.wiki/NPTA>)
- Writers described by RE, with RE authors
(<https://w.wiki/NPTn>)
- Writers described by RE, counted by RE authors
(<https://w.wiki/NPUS>)

...



3) Query examples and visualization of Wikidata statements in the Catalog of the Linked Ancient Greek and Latin (LAGL) project



onomastics.lagl.org

NEs related to ancient Greek and Latin personal names.



places.lagl.org

NEs related to ancient Greek and Latin place names.



misc.lagl.org

NEs related to miscellaneous proper names in ancient Greek and Latin.



NER spaCy based

NEs recognizer based on the Python library spaCy.



catalog.lagl.org

NEs related to ancient Greek and Latin authors and works.

LAGL.org

Linked Ancient Greek and Latin

Linked Open Data for ancient Greek and Latin
Named Entity Recognition and Annotation

<https://www.lagl.org>

Linked Ancient Greek and Latin LAGL

Catalog of Authors and Works

Herodotus - urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0016

Submit

LAGL Catalog of Authors and Works

This *Catalog* is part of the *Linked Ancient Greek and Latin (LAGL)* project and is populated with forms deriving from the linguistic extraction and annotation of expressions about authors and works in ancient Greek sources.

This is the first version of the *Catalog*, which shows data from the catalogs of the *Digital Athenaeus*, the *Digital Harpocraton*, and the *Digital Suda* projects. Forthcoming versions of the catalog will allow to search Greek forms and will be enriched with data from other sources, such as the works of Clement of Alexandria.

Annotated tokens of the *Catalog* can be visualized in the *Linguistic Catalog* of the LAGL project, where they are enriched with lemmata and Named Entity (NE) labels.

A dedicated [WikiProject LAGL](#) gathers contributors to discuss and establish consistent, uniform guidelines for using Wikidata properties to make statements about ancient authors, primarily based on linguistic data extracted from ancient sources. A direct link between the LAGL Catalog and Wikidata is provided by the *LAGL author ID* Wikidata Property ([P12869](#)) that collects identifiers of Ancient Greek and Latin authors from the LAGL Catalog.

Search Fields

- **Author name:** author name in the Latinized form according to the *TLG Canon* and the *Perseus Catalog* (e.g., [Xenophon](#)).
- **Author CTS URN:** author CTS URN according to the *Perseus Catalog* (e.g., [urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0032](#)). Authors not yet in the *TLG Canon* and in the *Perseus Catalog* are assigned new numbers with the prefix *lagl* (e.g., Arignote: [urn:cts:greekLit:lagl0309](#)).

<https://catalog.lagl.org>

LAGL author ID (P12869)

Property [Discussion](#)

Read [View history](#) [Tools](#) ▼

identifier for an Ancient Greek or Latin author in the LAGL Catalog of Authors and Works

▼ [In more languages](#)

[Configure](#)

Language	Label	Description	Also known as
default for all languages	No label defined	—	
English	LAGL author ID	identifier for an Ancient Greek or Latin author in the LAGL Catalog of Authors and Works	
German	No label defined	No description defined	
French	No label defined	No description defined	
Bavarian	No label defined	No description defined	

[All entered languages](#)

<https://www.wikidata.org/wiki/Property:P12869>

Let's query LAGL in Wikidata!

Examples:

- Wikidata items with LAGL author ID (P12869) (<https://w.wiki/Ern7>)
- Wikidata items with LAGL author ID (P12869) and locations (<https://w.wiki/NStn>)
- Wikidata items with LAGL author ID (P12869) and work-related properties (<https://w.wiki/FiQH>)

https://www.lagl.org/experimental_maps/LAGL_Authors_map_Wikidata_location_properties.html

https://www.lagl.org/experimental_metadata/LAGL_Authors_Wikidata_work_properties.html

```
SELECT ?item ?itemLabel ?laglAuthorID WHERE {  
  # Find Wikidata items that have a LAGL author ID.  
  # P12869 is the Wikidata property for the LAGL author identifier.  
  ?item wdt:P12869 ?laglAuthorID.  
  
  # Automatically fetch human-readable labels for returned Wikidata items.  
  # The label language is selected from the user's interface language if available,  
  # with English used as a fallback.  
  SERVICE wikibase:label {  
    bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "[AUTO_LANGUAGE],en".  
  }  
}
```

<https://w.wiki/Ern7>

```

# Display the query results using Wikidata Query Service's map view.
# Each result with coordinates will appear as a point on the map.
#defaultView:Map

SELECT DISTINCT ?item ?itemLabel ?location ?locationLabel ?coord WHERE {
  # Select Wikidata items that have a LAGL author ID.
  # P12869 is the Wikidata property for the LAGL author identifier.
  ?item wdt:P12869 ?laglID.

  # Define the set of location-related properties to check.
  # The query will look for any of these properties on each LAGL-linked item.
  VALUES ?locationProperty {
    wdt:P19      # place of birth
    wdt:P20      # place of death
    wdt:P27      # country of citizenship
    wdt:P66      # ancestral home
    wdt:P119     # place of burial
    wdt:P551     # residence
    wdt:P740     # location of formation
    wdt:P937     # work location
  }

  # Retrieve the location connected to the item through one of the properties above.
  ?item ?locationProperty ?location.

  # Keep only locations that have geographic coordinates.
  # P625 is the Wikidata property for coordinate location.
  ?location wdt:P625 ?coord.

  # Automatically fetch human-readable labels for the item and the location.
  # The service uses the user's interface language when available,
  # with English as a fallback.
  SERVICE wikibase:label {
    bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "[AUTO_LANGUAGE],en".
  }
}

```

<https://w.wiki/NStn>

```

SELECT ?item ?itemLabel ?lagl ?occupationLabel ?fieldLabel ?movementLabel ?genreLabel WHERE {
  # Select Wikidata items that have a LAGL author ID.
  # P12869 is the Wikidata property for the LAGL author identifier.
  ?item wdt:P12869 ?lagl .

  # Keep only items that have at least one of the following properties:
  # P106 = occupation
  # P101 = field of work
  # P135 = movement
  # P136 = genre
  #
  # The property path with | means "or".
  # The empty object [] means that any value is acceptable.
  FILTER EXISTS {
    ?item (wdt:P106|wdt:P101|wdt:P135|wdt:P136) []
  }

  # Optionally retrieve the item's occupation or occupations.
  # P106 is the Wikidata property for occupation.
  OPTIONAL {
    ?item wdt:P106 ?occupation
  }

  # Optionally retrieve the item's field or fields of work.
  # P101 is the Wikidata property for field of work.
  OPTIONAL {
    ?item wdt:P101 ?field
  }

  # Optionally retrieve the cultural, artistic, literary, or intellectual movement
  # associated with the item.
  # P135 is the Wikidata property for movement.
  OPTIONAL {
    ?item wdt:P135 ?movement
  }

  # Optionally retrieve genres associated with the item.
  # P136 is the Wikidata property for genre.
  OPTIONAL {
    ?item wdt:P136 ?genre
  }

  # Automatically fetch human-readable labels for the item and all optional values.
  # The service uses the user's interface language when available,
  # with English as a fallback.
  SERVICE wikibase:label {
    bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "[AUTO_LANGUAGE],en".
  }
}

# Sort the results by the LAGL author identifier.
ORDER BY ?lagl

```

<https://w.wiki/FiQH>

Catalog of Authors and Works

Herodotus - urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0016 ▾

Submit

Herodotus (Herodotus) - urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0016

Place of birth (Wikidata Statement)

Halicarnassus ([Wikidata](#)) ([Pleiades](#))

Places of death (Wikidata Statement)

Thurii ([Wikidata](#)) ([Pleiades](#))

Pella ([Wikidata](#)) ([Pleiades](#))

Occupations (Wikidata Statement)

historian ([Wikidata](#))

writer ([Wikidata](#))

geographer ([Wikidata](#))

politician ([Wikidata](#))

Ancient Sources

[urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0016](#) in Digital Atheneaus

[urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0016](#) in Digital Harpocraton

[urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0016](#) in Digital Suda

Digital Athenaeus Works

[urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0016.ath001](#) -  Histories

Digital Suda Works

[urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0016.suda001](#) -  Histories

<https://catalog.lagl.org/index.php?what=urn:cts:greekLit:tlg0016>

Wikidata:WikiProject LAGL

[Project page](#) [Discussion](#)

[Read](#) [Edit](#) [View history](#) [☆](#) [Tools](#) [v](#)

Wikidata item not found.

The goal of the **WikiProject LAGL** is to discuss the use of Wikidata properties for ancient authors and their works, as collected in the [LAGL Catalog](#) and other projects, such as [Hypotheses](#), [DataLib](#), [Greek Anthology project](#), [The Library of Polybius](#), [NIKAW](#), [TM Paradoxography](#), [ToposText](#) and [Stephanos of Byzantium](#).

The main objective of this discussion is to establish consistent, uniform guidelines for using Wikidata properties to make **statements about ancient authors, primarily based on linguistic data extracted from ancient sources**.

LAGL Project [\[edit \]](#)

[LAGL \(Linked Ancient Greek and Latin\)](#) is a project for annotating and extracting linguistic data from ancient Greek and Latin sources following the Linked Open Data (LOD) principles. The focus is on: (1) Named Entities (e.g., [Θησεύς](#) and [Ἀθήναι](#)) and (2) bibliographic references (e.g., [Ξενοφῶν ἐν τῇ Ἀναβάσει](#)). Part of the LAGL project is the [LAGL Catalog](#), which collects linguistic data on authors and works in ancient sources. The Wikidata ([LAGL author ID \(P12869\)](#)) property stores identifiers of ancient authors from the LAGL Catalog with direct links to linguistic annotations.

One of the main goals of the LAGL Project is to enrich linguistic data with metadata on ancient authors and works according to the Wikidata properties.

Experimental visualizations based on Wikidata properties for LAGL authors

- [LAGL Authors Wikidata live map](#)
- [LAGL Authors map with Wikidata location properties](#) and [database](#)
- [LAGL Authors Wikidata work-related properties](#)

Goals [\[edit \]](#)

- Prepare documentation to work in a consistent way on existing properties and values.
- Select (ancient) sources to extract assertions for Wikidata (with a particular focus on genre, geographical provenance, and chronology).
- Create queries.
- Assign tasks to contributors.
- Schedule meetings to discuss goals and tasks.

Wikidata properties for ancient authors [\[edit \]](#)

https://www.wikidata.org/wiki/Wikidata:WikiProject_LAGL

Main references (cf. [GitHub](#) page)

- Fantoli, M., Boano, V.I., de Graaf, E. and Pellizzari di San Girolamo, C.C. (2026) 'Wikidata as a Knowledge Base for People of the Greco-Roman World', Journal of Open Humanities Data, 12(1), p. 21. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.5334/johd.457>.
- Berti, M. (2025) 'Linked Ancient Greek and Latin (LAGL) and Wikidata: Structuring and Reusing Data of Classical Literature', Journal of Open Humanities Data, 11(1), p. 72. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.5334/johd.423>.

Further readings (cf. [GitHub](#) page)

- Vrandečić, D., Pintscher, L. and Krötzsch, M. (2023) 'Wikidata: The Making Of'. Companion Proceedings of the ACM Web Conference 2023, pp. 615-624. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1145/3543873.3585579>.
- Zhao, F. 'A Systematic Review of Wikidata in Digital Humanities Projects', Digital Scholarship in the Humanities, 38(2), pp. 852-874. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.1093/llc/fqac083>.
- Berti, M. (ed.) *Nomina Omina: Ancient Greek and Latin Proper Names in the Age of Artificial Intelligence*. Digital Classics Online. Themenheft 12,2. Heidelberg: Propylaeum 2026. Available at <https://doi.org/10.11588/dco.2026.12.2>.
- Pellizzari di San Girolamo, C. C. (2026) 'Hypotheseis, a Database of Named Entities Surrounding Greek Rhetorical Exercises', Digital Classics Online, 12(2), pp. 82-100. Available at: <https://doi.org/10.11588/dco.2026.12.112296>.